

DECODED EXPLAINED

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What India's 12 'Operationally Deployed' Nuclear Warheads Really Mean

KEYWORD

What India's 12 'operationally deployed' nuclear warheads really mean

SIPRI's latest assessment shows the maturation of India's second-strike capability rather than a shift away from its long-standing 'no first use' doctrine; the development comes amid a broader global trend of nuclear modernisation and weakening arms-control frameworks

Shrawan Shagun

The Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) released its annual yearbook in June. For the first time, it classified 12 of India's estimated stockpile of 150 nuclear warheads to be operationally deployed, i.e., positioned with active military forces mated with delivery systems and ready for use. This sounds alarming – but the alarm itself may not be warranted. The reason is that India has neither crossed a strategic threshold nor has it abandoned its decades-old 'no first use' policy.

India's promise

India's 'no first use' (NFU) policy is a pillar of its nuclear doctrine and its credible minimum deterrence posture. At the 1st High-Level Meeting commemorating the International Day for the Total Elimination of Nuclear Weapons in September 2025, India's representative Sibi George reaffirmed India's commitment to NFU and to the non-use of nuclear weapons against non-nuclear-weapon states.

The political foundations of the doctrine are intact even as some analysts within India have periodically called for a conditional or hybrid first-use posture. Those calls have not prevailed.

Under NFU, India commits to not launching a pre-emptive nuclear strike. What it needs is the absolute certainty that even after absorbing a nuclear first strike, enough of its nuclear arsenal will survive to deliver a devastating retaliatory blow. This survivability guarantee is what strategists call a second-strike capability and without it, NFU is not a doctrine but a liability. In other words, the doctrine depends on a force that can survive and retaliate.

The SIPRI report does not indicate a shift towards first use, a lowering of the threshold for nuclear employment or indeed any revision of the political controls that govern India's nuclear weapons. Instead, it documents the maturing of India's ability to credibly deliver the second strike.

Stockpile v. Deployment

This distinction is significant. Possessing a nuclear warhead and deploying it as part of an operational deterrent is not the same thing. For most of its nuclear history, India has kept its warheads in a de-mated state, meaning the warheads were stored separately from their delivery vehicles, in a central storage site and under strict civilian and political oversight. The idea was to maximise safety, reduce the risk of accidental use, and signal restraint to the international community.

Deployment, on the other hand, means a weapon has been paired with a delivery system – a missile, aircraft, or submarine – and positioned with operational military forces in a state of readiness. Again, this does not mean the weapons are about to be used; it means they are configured for use if authorised. A de-mated weapon requires time to prepare and deploy; a mated weapon can, in principle, be launched more quickly. What SIPRI has recorded when it classified 12 Indian warheads as being deployed is that a small – but no doubt



The Stockholm International Peace Research Institute noticed India's increasing reliance on canisterised Agni-series missiles. FILE PHOTO

significant – fraction of India's arsenal now is being maintained in a state of operational readiness. And SIPRI has linked this assessment to the maturation of India's nuclear triad, particularly its sea-based deterrent, suggesting that a small number of warheads may now be deployed aboard a nuclear ballistic missile submarine (which are also called SSBN) conducting occasional deterrence patrols.

India's Arihant-class submarines have steadily strengthened the survivability of the country's second-strike capability, with additional platforms expected to further consolidate this leg of the triad. SIPRI also noticed India's increasing reliance on canisterised Agni-series missiles. This means the missiles are kept ready with fuel in a sealed cylinder, from which they can be directly fired without further preparations. Canisterisation thus indicates a greater level of operational readiness.

Overall, it seems India's long-envisioned deterrent posture is becoming increasingly operational across land and sea-based delivery systems – but not that the country is on a war footing.

NFU architecture

Bearing in mind India's pursuit of a doctrine of credible minimum deterrence centred on assured retaliation, the maturation of its submarine-based deterrent doesn't depart from NFU but is a means of strengthening it. A doctrine that relies on retaliation requires forces capable of surviving an adversary's first strike. Land-based missiles, however capable, sit at known and mappable locations. An adversary confident in its intelligence could, in theory, target them in a disarming first strike before a retaliatory order is ever

issued. On the other hand, a stealthy submarine operating in the ocean can't be found, tracked or destroyed in time. This is a fundamental difference – and in fact, ballistic missile submarines provide the most secure second-strike capability available. As the scholar Vipin Nair has written, states pursuing assured retaliation postures must, above all, solve the survivability problem, and sea-basing is the most robust solution available.

India has now done that. With three operational SSBNs sufficient to keep at least one submerged and on patrol at all times, India has closed the central vulnerability any NFU doctrine faces.

Manpreet Sethi, distinguished fellow at the Centre for Aerospace Power and Strategic Studies, New Delhi, said, "With the operationalisation of tri-SSBNs, it is not surprising that some of India's nuclear warheads now stand mated with delivery platforms. This in no way implies a doctrinal shift. Rather, it makes assured retaliation more credible and, hence, India more confident in its commitment to 'no first use'."

Wider warning

SIPRI's documentation of India's deployment milestone lies within a broader, more concerning global trend. The organisation's 2025 Yearbook observed that states are "increasingly relying on nuclear weapons as instruments of national power", signalling a reversal of decades of gradual progress in disarmament.

As of January this year, the world's nine nuclear-armed states collectively possessed an estimated 12,187 nuclear warheads. China's arsenal has grown to approximately 620 and continues to expand at a pace unmatched by any other

nuclear power. In this context, India's reported deployment of 12 operationally assigned warheads is strategically significant.

India's nuclear choices must be understood from within this evolving security environment. SIPRI has noted that India's modernisation programme is increasingly focused on developing long-range delivery systems capable of reaching targets throughout China – while continuing to account for Pakistan.

With China's arsenal now more than three times the size of Pakistan's estimated stockpile, and Beijing simultaneously expanding its sea-based nuclear deterrent, India's SSBN programme appears directed as much towards maintaining credible deterrence against China as towards preserving stability with Pakistan.

The world that the SIPRI report has described is one in which the post-Cold War nuclear order is under mounting strain. Arms-control agreements have weakened or collapsed while competition in areas such as hypersonic delivery systems, artificial intelligence-enabled decision support, missile defence, and anti-submarine warfare continues to intensify.

The risk of miscalculation is correspondingly increasing. India's evolving deterrent posture should therefore be seen not as an isolated development but as part of a wider transformation in the global strategic environment. Policymakers should treat this as a warning that the institutions designed to manage nuclear risk must adapt quickly enough to keep pace with the capabilities now being fielded. (Shrawan Shagun is a researcher focusing on environmental sustainability and space governance)

What India's 12 'Operationally Deployed' Nuclear Warheads Really Mean

About SIPRI

SIPRI is an **independent international institute** dedicated to research into conflict, armaments, arms control and disarmament. It is based in Stockholm.

It was established in 1966 and provides data, analysis and recommendations, based on open sources, to policymakers, researchers, media and the interested public.

Funding: **It was established on the basis of a decision by the Swedish Parliament and receives a substantial part of its funding in the form of an annual grant from the Swedish Government.**

The Institute also seeks financial support from other organizations in order to carry out its research.

What India's 12 'Operationally Deployed' Nuclear Warheads Really Mean

Report Highlights :

India's estimated nuclear arsenal increased to 190 warheads, up from 180 the previous year.

India retained its position as the world's fifth-largest military spender in 2025.

India also remained the world's second-largest importer of major arms during the 2021-25 period, accounting for 8.2% of global arms imports.

What India's 12 'Operationally Deployed' Nuclear Warheads Really Mean

Growing Dependence on Nuclear Weapons: Nuclear-armed states are placing greater emphasis on nuclear deterrence in their security strategies. This marks a reversal of decades-long efforts to reduce the role and number of nuclear weapons.

Expansion and Modernisation of Arsenals: All nine nuclear-armed states, the United States, Russia, United Kingdom, France, China, India, Pakistan, North Korea and Israel continued modernization programmes and deployed new nuclear-capable systems in 2025.

Global Nuclear Stockpile: Estimated global inventory (January 2026): 12,187 nuclear warheads. **Russia and the USA together possess around 83%** of all stockpiled nuclear warheads.

What India's 12 'Operationally Deployed' Nuclear Warheads Really Mean

Stockpile vs. Deployment

- For most of its nuclear history, India kept warheads in a “de-mated” state : stored separately from delivery vehicles in a central storage site under strict civilian and political oversight, to maximise safety, reduce the risk of accidental use, and signal restraint
- A “deployed” weapon means it has been paired with a delivery system (missile, aircraft or submarine) and positioned with operational military forces in a state of readiness it does not mean weapons are configured for use; a mated weapon can, in principle, be launched more quickly

What India's 12 'Operationally Deployed' Nuclear Warheads Really Mean

Problem : SIPRI's Classification

○ The Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) released its annual yearbook in June, classifying 12 of India's estimated stockpile of 190 nuclear warheads as “operationally deployed” for the first time

India's NFU Policy

NFU: India commits to not launching a pre-emptive nuclear strike; what is needed is absolute certainty that even after absorbing a first strike, enough of its nuclear arsenal will survive to deliver a devastating retaliatory blow this survivability guarantee is what strategists call second-strike capability

Building a Credible Minimum Deterrence : Deter any nation from using nuclear weapons against India

Massive Retaliation based on Mutually assured destruction (MAD) Doctrine

What India's 12 'Operationally Deployed' Nuclear Warheads Really Mean

Authorisation

Nuclear Command Authority

Political Council : Headed by Prime Minister

Executive Council : Headed by NSA

Union Cabinet Okays ₹30,000 Cr. Additional Investment in NIIF for New Fund Creation

Union Cabinet okays ₹30,000 cr. additional investment in NIIF for new fund creation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



The Union Cabinet has approved an additional investment by the Government of India of ₹30,000 crore in the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF) to be used for its upcoming funds, the government announced on Monday.

The decision itself was taken last week, it said. This would take the government's total commitment in NIIF to ₹60,000 crore. The NIIF is India's sovereign anchored fund, in which the government of India is a 49% shareholder. It currently manages capital commitments of about ₹40,000 crore across its funds and investment strategies, the government said.

"We are grateful for this allocation of ₹30,000 crore, which is a strong reaffirmation of Government support to NIIF and reinforces the catalytic capital model that has defined NIIF since inception," Sanjiv Aggarwal, Managing Director and CEO of NIIF said.

New fund

According to a release by NIIF, this additional allocation from the government will help NIIF raise larger funds, attract investors across geographies, and deepen its presence in key sectors of the economy.

This additional investment of ₹30,000 crore will be used to set up NIIF's second infrastructure focussed fund, the successor to its first flagship fund with this mandate

The government said that this additional investment of ₹30,000 crore will be used to set up NIIF's second infrastructure focussed fund, the successor to its first flagship fund with this mandate.

"NIIF Infrastructure Fund II is proposed to have a target corpus of close to ₹30,000 crore and is expected to undertake investments across transportation, energy, digital infrastructure, and emerging areas such as urban infrastructure and e-mobility," the government release said.

It added that the allocation will also support NIIF's new fund strategies and upcoming bilateral and strategic funds.

"Over the past decade, Govt's anchor commitment has enabled us to build a very strong institutional investor base, spanning leading sovereign wealth funds, pension funds, multilateral and bilateral institutions, and domestic financial institutions," Mr. Aggarwal added.

What India's 12 'Operationally Deployed' Nuclear Warheads Really Mean

- **The Decision**

- The Union Cabinet has approved an additional Government of India investment of ₹30,000 crore in the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF), taking the government's total commitment in NIIF to ₹60,000 crore

- **About NIIF**

- NIIF is India's sovereign anchored fund, in which the Government of India is a 49% shareholder
- It currently manages capital commitments of about ₹40,000 crore across its funds and investment strategies
- The GoI's anchor commitment has enabled NIIF to build an investor base spanning leading sovereign wealth funds, pension funds, multilateral and bilateral institutions, and domestic financial institutions

- **Significance**

- The “catalytic capital model” : government as anchor investor attracting large private and international co-investors has defined NIIF since inception; this additional allocation reinforces that model
- Will help NIIF raise larger funds, attract investors across geographies, and deepen its presence in key sectors of the economy

Union Cabinet Okays ₹30,000 Cr. Additional Investment in NIIF for New Fund Creation

With reference to 'National Investment and Infrastructure Fund', which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. It is an organ of NITI Aayog.
2. It has a corpus of Rs 4,00,000 crore at present.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

This question was previously asked in
UPSC Civil Services (Prelims)
General Studies Official Paper-I...

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1. 1 only

2. 2 only

3. Both 1 and 2

4. Neither 1 nor 2

Why More Medicines Will Now Have QR Codes on Their Packets

Why more medicines will now have QR codes on their packets

Anonna Dutt

New Delhi, June 29

THE CENTRE has recently mandated that all vaccines, antimicrobials, narcotics and addictive drugs, and anti-cancer drugs carry a bar code or QR code, to enable tracking of each vial or blister pack of the medicine. This track-and-trace mechanism allows regulators as well as manufacturers to follow the entire journey of every unit of the product, from the manufacturing plant to the retail store.

This is already applicable for 300 top brands of drugs, such as the gastric reflux tablet Aciloc and fever medicines like Calpol.

The mechanism will be implemented for the new categories over the next two years — by July 2027 for vaccines, narcotics, and anticancer drugs and by July 2028 for antimicrobials, according to the recent gazette notification.

How does the tracking system work?

In addition to the unique identification number for the particular blister pack or vial, the QR code or bar code also has to

carry the brand name and generic name of the drug, name and address of the manufacturer, batch number, date of manufacturing, date of expiry, and manufacturing licence number.

While most drugs in the market already carry this information on their pack, the QR code-based tracking system requires the manufacturers, wholesalers, distributors, and retailers to log these products on specialised track and trace platforms.

“This mechanism makes counterfeiting difficult. Some may still use AI to generate codes similar to the original product, but with each unit carrying a unique code, that becomes difficult,” said an industry expert, adding, “Even using the original packaging to refill and sell counterfeit drug is not likely to work because once the drug has been registered on the platform, the same number cannot be re-registered.”

“The enhanced traceability mechanism will facilitate authentication of medicines at various stages of the supply chain and enable improved tracking and verification of drug products. The measure is expected to strengthen regulatory oversight and support efforts to curb the distribution of spurious medicines in the market,” said the

Past cases

● The use of this mechanism to track expensive cancer drugs is specially significant, considering there have been instances where used vials have been filled with other medicines and sold to desperate patients.

● A recent investigation by ‘The Indian Express’ had tracked one such ring that counterfeited the cancer immunotherapy drug Keytruda.

Union Health Ministry in a statement.

Why is it needed?

The main aim is to prevent counterfeiting. A drug can be counterfeited by either releasing products with no active ingredient into the market or diluting a drug to increase quantities for sale.

The track and trace mechanism can help regulators identify whether a product was contaminated at the source — at the manufacturing plant of a company — or was tampered with.

The possibility of tracking every single unit also means that regulators and companies know exactly where to find their products in case there is a recall.

What are the challenges?

One of the challenges, an industry expert said, is that if there is a delay in logging the genuine product and a counterfeit gets logged into the system, the genuine drug might come across as counterfeit.

Second is the challenge of cost. Companies will have to put in place mechanisms to generate the unique codes and the tracking platforms, incurring significant expense.

The expert said: “While it may be feasible for companies selling expensive cancer drugs, smaller companies will struggle. Considering that many of the drugs in schedule H2 are ‘essential’ and therefore under price control, the government may provide some monetary support or allow the companies to raise the prices slightly.”

How does it change regulatory oversight?

Another reason for implementing the tracking mechanism is to improve the maturity level of the Indian drug regulator. The World Health Organization has a benchmark tool for rating regulators depending on the way drugs are approved, the mechanisms for surveillance and testing, and ways of recalling products.

When it comes to vaccines, the Indian regulator is already at Maturity Level 3, the second-best. Making each unit of a vaccine traceable is a step towards achieving the highest level, Maturity Level 4. Higher the maturity level, the easier it is for medicines from the country to be accepted in international markets, as their quality is seen as more trustworthy.

Why More Medicines Will Now Have QR Codes on Their Packets

- **The Mandate**

- The Centre has mandated that all vaccines, antimicrobials, narcotics and addictive drugs, and anti-cancer drugs carry a bar code or QR code, enabling tracking of each vial or blister pack from the manufacturing plant to the retail store
- Already applicable for 300 top brands (e.g., Aciloc, Calpol); the mechanism will be extended to new categories over the next two years by July 2027 for vaccines, narcotics, and anti-cancer drugs, and by July 2028 for antimicrobials

- **How the Track-and-Trace System Works**

- The QR/barcode carries: brand name, generic name, manufacturer name and address, batch number, date of manufacturing, date of expiry, and manufacturing licence number
- The system requires manufacturers, wholesalers, distributors, and retailers to log products on specialised track-and-trace platforms
- Since each unit carries a unique code and gets registered, counterfeiting becomes very difficult — the same number cannot be re-registered for a counterfeit product

Behind Europe's Heatwave, Climate Change the Culprit

Behind Europe's heatwave, climate change the culprit



AMITABH SINHA

A NEW study has confirmed what was already evident — climate change is behind the scorching heat in large parts of Europe right now.

A study by World Weather Attribution (WWA), a group of scientists that examines the causes of extreme weather events worldwide, has found climate change to be "unequivocally to blame" for the European heatwave, which has seen several places record unprecedented temperatures in recent days. WWA said this was the most severe heatwave ever recorded in Europe.

On Sunday, WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus wrote in a post on X that "Europe is the fastest-warming continent on Earth, heating at twice the global average... More than 1300 excess deaths have been recorded since 21 June linked to high temperatures in Europe."

This is the third time in five years that Europe finds itself in the grip of an intense heatwave. Similar scenes were witnessed in 2022 and 2023 as well. More than 100,000 people are estimated to have died owing to extreme heat in those two years.

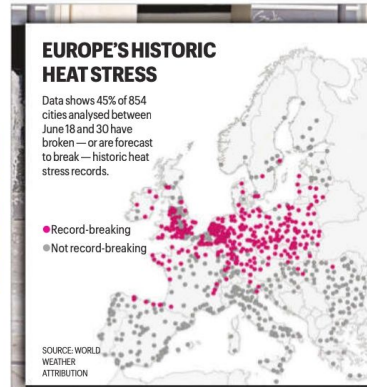
While the current episode of extreme heat is expected to slightly subside this weekend onwards, Europe's ordeal might not be over yet, according to forecasts by meteorological offices of the UK and France. Historically, June has not been the hottest month for Europe — July is. With the El Niño phenomenon in the Pacific Ocean expected to get stronger in July, Europe might be staring at fresh heatwave spells in the coming weeks.

Climate change-driven heatwave

The WWA study, however, was categorical in assigning the blame of this heatwave. It said it was not because of El Niño, which is still to reach its peak, or any other reason, but climate change.

"Both the daytime highs and overnight temperatures seen during this heatwave would have been virtually impossible to occur at this time of year as recently as 1976 — just 50 years ago," it said.

Many of the temperature records now being broken in Europe were set in 1976, when the region had experienced an un-



usually hot summer.

Europe experienced its first heatwave of this century in 2003. The study said that heatwave was nothing in comparison to what the region is witnessing now. The record-breaking high temperatures during the night are almost 100 times more likely today than they were in 2003, it said. The daytime peak temperatures observed during the current spell are almost 10 times more likely.

Daytime temperatures in most of Europe, barring the northern part, are usually between 20 and 30°C during June. Night-time temperatures typically vary between 11 and 17°C. But in many parts of the region, peak temperatures during the ongoing heatwave have been 10 to 15°C higher than normal. A similar situation had prevailed in May this year as well, when an early heatwave had prevailed in Europe.

"The analysis found that the El Niño Southern Oscillation (ENSO) phase had no role in driving the heat (in this spell)," the study said.

ENSO is an ocean-atmospheric interaction over the Pacific Ocean region. El Niño is one of the two phases of ENSO and is known to have a warming effect on the planet. Its opposite phase, La Niña, tends to bring temperatures down.

Why accurate attribution is important

Though the intensity of this particular

Concrete evidence

Climate attribution science is a relatively new discipline. It examines the likelihood of a particular extreme weather event, if climate change were not taking place.

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Attribution science seeks to remove ambiguity and determine the exact extent of responsibility that climate change bears.

spell of European heatwave and the trend over the last few years had made the imprint of climate change fairly clear, scientists are usually wary of linking any individual extreme weather event to climate change without an attribution study like this one.

Climate attribution science is a relatively new discipline, developed just over the last two decades. It tries to examine the likelihood of a particular extreme weather event happening if climate change were not taking place.

Earlier, it used to take scientists a couple of months, even years, to make this assessment. But in the last three to four years, mainly owing to the efforts of WWA, a much faster assessment has been made possible, sometimes even when the event is still ongoing, as in the present case.

Attribution science seeks to remove ambiguity and determine the exact extent of responsibility of climate change in causing major extreme weather events.

In the last few years, it has established the footprints of climate change on several events. Besides preparing scientific evidence, this exercise is also aimed at forcing policymakers and decision-makers to act more rapidly on climate change.

Action awaited

The scientific evidence on climate change is already voluminous and compel-

While the link may seem self-evident, establishing scientific cause is key to driving policy action, which has been lacking



ling. Still, climate change seems to have dropped a few notches down in the list of global priorities, particularly after Donald Trump took office as US President. The recent G7 meetings, for example, hardly had any climate-related agenda or outcomes. A few years earlier, climate change used to be one of the most important items at such international meetings, especially those involving influential leaders.

Scientists insist that there is still time for countries to take rapid action and attempt to achieve the Paris Agreement targets of containing the global rise of temperatures within 1.5 or 2°C from pre-industrial times.

But governments appear to have all but given up on those targets. For them, it seems, these targets have already gone beyond reach, or require the kind of mobilisation of resources on a global scale that is neither practical nor realistic to organise.

Countries seem to have decided to let climate change play itself out and do their best to deal with its impact and adapt to it — a strategy scientists routinely warn against. Adaptation has its limits, they maintain.

But global action on climate change has continued to woefully lag behind global warming. Events such as the European heatwave are only expected to increase both in frequency and intensity over the next few years.

Behind Europe's Heatwave, Climate Change the Culprit

● The Event

- Large parts of Europe have been experiencing record-breaking heat; 45% of 854 European cities analysed between June 18 and 30 have broken or are forecast to break historic heat stress records
- This is the third time in five years Europe has found itself in the grip of an intense heatwave (also in 2022 and 2023); more than 1,00,000 people are estimated to have died owing to extreme heat in those two years alone
- WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus has noted Europe is heating at twice the global average; more than 1,300 excess deaths recorded since June 21

● Climate Attribution Science

- A study by World Weather Attribution (WWA) found climate change to be “unequivocally to blame” for the European heatwave
- El Niño Southern Oscillation (ENSO) had no role in driving the heat in this current spell — the cause is climate change
- Record-breaking high temperatures during night are now almost 100 times more likely today than in 2003; daytime peak temperatures during the ongoing heatwave are almost 10 times more likely
- Climate attribution science: a relatively new discipline that examines the likelihood of a particular extreme weather event happening if climate change were not occurring — it seeks to remove ambiguity and determine the exact extent of responsibility that climate change bears for major extreme weather events

Caught in the Middle: India Must Prioritise Reduction of Harm from Drug Abuse

Caught in the middle

India must prioritise reduction of harm from drug abuse

India is located between two major drug-producing regions: Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Iran to the west and Myanmar, Thailand, and Laos to the east. While the West has historically dominated heroin production, the International Narcotics Control Board has said Myanmar has become the world's leading source of illicit opium while East and Southeast Asia remain major sources of methamphetamine. Officials have said drugs are being received at Gujarat, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu via maritime routes. Similarly, some drugs are produced domestically using illegally diverted pharmaceutical ingredients, aided by the fact that individuals possessing small quantities of heroin can attract up to six months' imprisonment, whereas drugmakers that cannot account for lakhs of doses often face only slaps on the wrist. The rise of Myanmar, where the territory under ethnic armed organisations is expanding, as a key source is also troubling since it shares a border with India. The Narcotics Control Bureau has noted a dramatic surge in the use of drones to smuggle drugs across borders, especially over Punjab. Traffickers are organising over the darknet and using cryptocurrencies. The pillars of India's response thus aim to keep the enforcement regime from being out-innovated and improve regulatory certainty.

States are trying to adopt a 'whole of society' approach recognising the public health and social dimensions. However, India needs to do more. Physical abuse and forced detoxification are frequently reported from many private centres. Punjab has an extensive network of de-addiction centres providing opioid substitution therapy, and some northeastern States to a secondary extent, but most large States have much less access relative to need. Most Integrated Rehabilitation Centres for Addicts are located in urban areas whereas the highest density of addicts in Punjab are in border villages and rural pockets. Likewise, relapse is often treated as a moral failure and many addicts avoid government centres fearing social ostracisation, particularly in rural North India. The persistence of criminal records for small-scale possession prevents youth from getting jobs, reducing their odds of escaping the drug-crime cycle. Although the *Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyaan* has said it has sensitised over six crore women, facilities dedicated to women are scarce and concentrated in urban areas; stigma, caregiving responsibilities, and lack of gender-responsive treatment keep many women from seeking or completing care. Finally, as evidence shows, disrupted supply can drive many users to cheaper alternatives unless accompanied by effective treatment. India must therefore shift public focus from seizures and arrests to the number of lives restored.

Caught in the Middle: India Must Prioritise Reduction of Harm from Drug Abuse

● India's Geographic Vulnerability

- India is located between two major drug-producing regions: the “Golden Crescent” (Afghanistan, Pakistan, Iran) to the west and the “Golden Triangle” (Myanmar, Thailand, Laos) to the east
- The International Narcotics Control Board has noted Myanmar has become the world's leading source of illicit opium; East and Southeast Asia remain major sources of methamphetamine
- Drugs are received at Gujarat, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu via maritime routes; some are also produced domestically using illegally diverted pharmaceutical ingredients
- The Narcotics Control Bureau has noted a dramatic surge in drone-based smuggling, especially over Punjab; traffickers organise on the darknet and use cryptocurrencies

● The Policy Paradox

- Individuals possessing small quantities of heroin can attract up to six months' imprisonment, whereas drugmakers unable to account for lakhs of doses often face only minor penalties, the enforcement focus is disproportionately on users, not suppliers
- India must shift public focus from seizures and arrests to the number of lives restored

Caught in the Middle: India Must Prioritise Reduction of Harm from Drug Abuse

● Treatment and Rehabilitation Gaps

- Physical abuse and forced detoxification are frequently reported from many private de-addiction centres
- Most Integrated Rehabilitation Centres for Addicts are in urban areas, while the highest density of addicts in Punjab is in border villages and rural pockets
- Relapse is often treated as a moral failure; criminal records for small-scale possession prevent youth from getting jobs, reducing their odds of escaping the drug-crime cycle
- Although Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyan claims to have sensitised over 6 crore women, facilities dedicated to women are scarce, concentrated in urban areas, and lack gender-responsive treatment

● The Way Forward

- India needs a “whole of society” approach recognising the public health and social dimensions of drug abuse, not just the enforcement dimension
- Punjab has an extensive network providing opioid substitution therapy; this model should be expanded to other large States that currently have much less access relative to need

Narcotics Control Bureau

Headquartered in New Delhi, NCB is the apex drug law enforcement and intelligence agency in India, constituted in 1986 under the provisions of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, 1985.

Functions and Powers of NCB: Operates under the Ministry of Home Affairs and coordinates with various central and state agencies for enforcement and policy implementation.

Operation Global-Hunt

About: Operation Global-Hunt is a three-year strategic initiative to dismantle around 100 international drug networks run by Indian fugitives, targeting traffickers dealing in heroin, cocaine, fentanyl and synthetic drugs through tools like INTERPOL notices and asset freezing.

Caught in the Middle: India Must Prioritise Reduction of Harm from Drug Abuse

International Narcotics Control Board

Established in 1968 by the Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs of 1961.

Headquarter based in Vienna, Austria, with a Secretariat supporting its activities.

Membership consists of 13 members elected by ECOSOC, experts in drug control and related fields.

Surveillance Boost: Army to Raise 'Baaz Battalions'

Surveillance boost: Army to raise 'Baaz Battalions'

The Hindu Bureau

NEW DELHI

The Indian Army is raising dedicated 'Baaz Battalions' to significantly enhance its Remotely Piloted Aircraft (RPA) capability, a move aimed at strengthening battlefield surveillance, intelligence gathering and rapid response through a specialised drone force, defence sources said.

Sources in the Indian Army have confirmed the development and said that the new battalions will be built upon the Army's existing RPA Flights and will comprise a specialist pool of trained personnel responsible for operating and managing Remotely Piloted Aircraft systems.

The Baaz Battalions will centralise the Army's expanding drone capabilities and will be designed to handle the entire lifecycle of RPA operations.

Surveillance Boost: Army to Raise 'Baaz Battalions'

● The Development

- The Indian Army is raising dedicated 'Baaz Battalions' to significantly enhance its Remotely Piloted Aircraft (RPA) capability
- The move is aimed at strengthening battlefield surveillance, intelligence gathering and rapid response through a specialised drone force

● Structure

- The new battalions will be built upon the Army's existing RPA Flights and will comprise a specialist pool of trained personnel responsible for operating and managing RPA systems
- The Baaz Battalions will centralise the Army's expanding drone capabilities and will be designed to handle the entire lifecycle of RPA operations

● Strategic Significance

- The move comes in the context of Operation Sindoor and other recent operations where drone-based surveillance and intelligence played a decisive role
- Dedicated RPA battalions mark a shift from drones as supplementary tools to drones as a core, institutionalised battlefield capability within the Army's organisational structure
- The emphasis reflects broader lessons from conflicts globally (Ukraine, West Asia) where drone warfare has emerged as a decisive and cost-effective force multiplier

Surveillance Boost: Army to Raise 'Baaz Battalions'

Q. With reference to Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), consider the following statements:

- I. All types of UAVs can do vertical landing.
- II. All types of UAVs can do automated hovering.
- III. All types of UAVs can use battery only as a source of power supply.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

[A] Only one

[B] Only two

[C] All the three

[D] None

Thank You